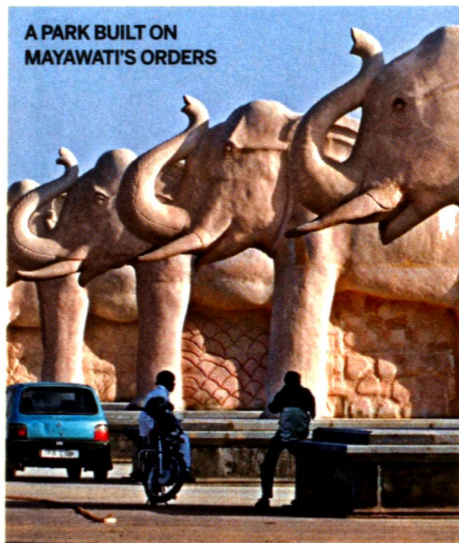


LUCKNOW | Hidden Costs



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI/www.indiatodayimages.com

Mayawati's claim that just 1 per cent of the state's funds have been spent on parks and memorials has fallen flat after an RTI filed by Congress leader Akhilesh Pratap Singh revealed the real fund flow into her muses.

July 2007 to December 2007:

Rs 2,289.84 crore

January 2008 to December 2008:

Rs 1,574.82 crore

January 2009 to July 2009:

Rs 518.85 crore

Totalling Rs 4,383.51 crore, these are the figures revealed by just one department, the State Construction Corporation. **by Farzand Ahmed**

KOLKATA | In the Doc

Even the supporters of the Left Front are shocked. This is because the medical allowances for West Bengal's ministers have kept growing. The allocation of medical benefits has trebled over the last three years. It was Rs 21 lakh in 2008, Rs 36 lakh in 2009 and is already Rs 76 lakh. This was no doubt done keeping in mind the fact that the average age of the state's ministers is over 65. Industries and Power Minister Nirupam Sen and Housing Minister Gautam Deb have not been well for a while. Assembly Speaker Hashim Abdul Halim, 75, recently fainted in Singapore. Power minister Mrinal Banerjee died in February from cancer. The medical allowance also includes healthcare for a significant number of the ministers' close kin.

by Abhijit Dasgupta

DELHI | Biological Bomb

THE WORLD'S HOTTEST CHILLIES WILL NOW BE PUT INTO HAND GRENADES FOR POLICE OPERATIONS.

Move over tear gas grenades, here come chilli bombs. The next time the Indian Army or police forces face terrorists or simple law and order disturbances, they will be hurling spices at assailants—special chilli grenades developed from Naga chillies (*Capsicum frutescens*), the world's hottest. The brainchild of the Defence Research Development Organisation's (DRDO) Tezpur laboratory, the grenades will immobilise but not kill assailants. "This is the world's first weaponised variant of a biological substance," says DRDO's chief controller W. Selvamurthy. **by Sandeep Unnithan**

HAJI ALI HAS ONLY THREE POLICEMEN INSIDE THE MOSQUE.

MUMBAI | Dargah Alert

The state Government, it seems, hasn't learnt much from 26/11. Even after a terror alert from the Centre last month, centred particularly around the coastal areas of Mumbai, the Government hasn't done much to secure the Haji Ali mosque. Members of the Haji Ali Dargah Trust have now sent a letter to Commissioner of Police D. Sivanandan and state Home Minister R.R. Patil,

PILGRIMS AT HAJI ALI



demanding greater security. A.S. Merchant, chairman and managing trustee of the trust, says that only three policemen have been deployed inside the dargah, and a few outside. His prime concern is a number of unauthorised hawkers roving about the mosque. Following the terror alert, the police had asked the trust to install CCTV cameras at the dargah, which Merchant claims are not being monitored by the police. **by Mitali Patel**